

Accessibility Review

A practical, WCAG 2.2-referenced audit of headings, contrast, focus visibility, text alternatives and motion settings.



Technical outcomes

By the end of this session you can run a structured accessibility audit, not just eyeball a page.

Audit

Run the five-part practical check against a real page: headings, contrast, focus, text alternatives, motion.

Cite

Attach the specific WCAG 2.2 success criterion to every finding — not just “this feels wrong”.

Fix

Propose one concrete, testable revision per finding and know how you would confirm it worked.

Review is a different skill from building

A page can look finished and still fail people who don't browse the way you do.

Building teaches you to make something work for yourself, on your machine, with your mouse and your eyesight. Reviewing asks a harder question: does it work for someone who tabs through with a keyboard, listens with a screen reader, or needs 200% zoom?

Passive assumption

“It looks fine to me” treats one body and one set of tools as the default reader.

Active review

A structured audit checks the page against named criteria, using the tools an actual reader would use.

WCAG in one slide

The Web Content Accessibility Guidelines give the audit its vocabulary and its pass/fail line.

Level	Meaning	Use in practice
A	Minimum	Absolute baseline; failing A blocks basic access for some users
AA	Course and industry target	The level this course, and most organisations, design and test to
AAA	Enhanced	Not achievable for all content types; used selectively

Reference: W3C, Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2, October 2023.

POUR — the four principles

Every WCAG success criterion sits under one of four principles.

Principle	Requirement	Audit example
Perceivable	Information must be presentable so users can perceive it	Alt text, captions, contrast
Operable	Interface and navigation must be operable	Keyboard access, focus order, no traps
Understandable	Information and operation must be understandable	Clear labels, predictable navigation
Robust	Content must work with current and future assistive tech	Valid markup, correct roles and names

The five-part practical audit

The checklist this session's studio audit works through, with the WCAG reference for each part.

Check	WCAG reference	Pass looks like
Headings	1.3.1 Info and Relationships	Logical order, no skipped levels
Contrast	1.4.3 / 1.4.11	4.5:1 text, 3:1 UI components and graphics
Focus visibility	2.4.7 / 2.4.11	Every interactive element shows a visible indicator
Text alternatives	1.1.1 Non-text Content	Every non-text item has a role-appropriate alt
Motion settings	2.2.2 / 2.3.3	Animation can be paused; no unconsented vestibular triggers

Check 1 / 5 — heading structure

A heading sequence is the outline a screen reader user hears before anything else.

WCAG 1.3.1 Info and Relationships requires that structure conveyed visually is also conveyed in markup. A heading skips from h2 straight to h4 breaks that relationship even if it still looks fine on screen.

Pass

Fail



Heading audit method

A repeatable four-step check for any page.

1

List every heading on the page in order, ignoring the body text between them.

2

Read the list alone — does it form a coherent outline of the page?

3

Check that heading levels nest without skipping (h2 → h3, never h2 → h4).

4

Confirm each landmark region (nav, main, aside) has at most one heading naming it.

Run this with a browser's accessibility tree or headings-list extension, not just by eye.

Check 2 / 5 — colour contrast

Contrast is measured as a ratio, not a subjective impression of legibility.

WCAG 1.4.3 sets a 4.5:1 minimum contrast ratio for normal text and 3:1 for large text (AA). WCAG 1.4.11 extends a 3:1 minimum to UI components and meaningful graphics, such as button borders and icons.



Pass

You passed this check. All content has sufficient contrast.



Fail

You failed this check. Some content does not have sufficient contrast.



Contrast audit method

A measured check, repeated for every distinct colour pairing on the page.

1

List every foreground/background colour pairing used for text, icons and borders.

2

Measure each pairing's ratio with a contrast-checking tool.

3

Record the ratio next to the required threshold for that pairing's role.

4

Flag any pairing under threshold and note the specific hex values involved.

Tool: WebAIM Contrast Checker or a browser DevTools contrast inspector; both report a numeric ratio.

Check 3 / 5 — focus visibility

A keyboard user only knows where they are on a page from a visible focus indicator.

WCAG 2.4.7 Focus Visible requires a visible indicator on every focusable element. **WCAG 2.4.11 Focus Not Obscured** (new in 2.2) requires that indicator not be hidden behind a sticky header or overlay.



Pass

WCAG 2.4.7 Focus Visible



Fail

WCAG 2.4.11 Focus Not Obscured



Keyboard navigation audit method

Unplug the mouse and try to complete the page's core task.

1

Disconnect or ignore the mouse; use Tab, Shift+Tab, Enter and Space only.

2

Confirm the tab order matches the visual reading order (WCAG 2.4.3).

3

Check every menu, modal and form can be opened, used and closed by keyboard.

4

Confirm nothing traps focus so it cannot be tabbed back out (WCAG 2.1.2).

A keyboard trap inside a modal is one of the most common, and most severe, findings in a real audit.

Check 4 / 5 — text alternatives

Every non-text item needs an alternative that matches its role, not a generic label.

WCAG 1.1.1 Non-text Content requires a text alternative that serves the same purpose. A decorative image gets an empty alt; an informative image gets a description; a functional icon gets the action it performs.

Pass

Fail



Text alternative audit method

Classify before you write — the right alt text depends on the image's job.

1

List every image, icon and SVG on the page.

2

Classify each as decorative, informative, functional or complex.

3

Write or check alt text matched to that role (empty for decorative, descriptive for informative).

4

Turn off images in the browser and confirm the page still makes sense.

For a complex image such as a chart, put the full explanation in visible or linked text, not only in the alt attribute.

Assistive technology in practice

An automated scan cannot tell you what a real screen-reader pass reveals.

Automated tools check for missing attributes and structural errors, not for whether the experience actually makes sense read aloud, navigated by switch, or controlled by voice. A real audit runs the page with the tool a reader would use.

Screen readers

Placeholder text for screen readers section.

Switch and voice control

Placeholder text for switch and voice control section.



Captions and media alternatives

Audio and video content need their own, separate accessible versions.

WCAG 1.2.2 requires captions for prerecorded audio in video; 1.2.4 extends this to live audio; 1.2.5 asks for audio description of important visual information a viewer would otherwise miss.

Pass

Fail



Check 5 / 5 — motion and animation settings

Movement on screen can disorient or physically harm some readers.

WCAG 2.2.2 Pause, Stop, Hide requires a control for any moving, blinking or auto-updating content lasting more than five seconds. **WCAG 2.3.3 (AAA)** asks that motion triggered by interaction can be disabled entirely for readers who experience vestibular discomfort.



Pass

An auto-advancing carousel has a visible pause button; the page honours prefers-reduced-motion.



Fail

Background video autoplays with no pause control, or a parallax effect cannot be turned off.

Motion audit method

Check both the default experience and the reduced-motion experience.

1

List every animation, auto-playing carousel, video and auto-refreshing region on the page.

2

Confirm each one lasting over five seconds has a visible pause, stop or hide control.

3

Enable the OS or browser's reduced-motion setting and reload the page.

4

Confirm large parallax or zoom effects are removed or substantially reduced under that setting.

Test with prefers-reduced-motion: reduce active — this is a real, checkable browser setting, not a theoretical one.

Zoom, reflow and text resize

Low vision is far more common than total blindness, and easier to test for.

WCAG 1.4.4 requires text to remain readable and functional at 200% zoom. WCAG 1.4.10 Reflow requires content to reflow into a single column at that zoom, without needing to scroll in two directions.



Pass



Fail

at night, carrying whispers
down, streetlights hummed
each other, their windows
d's paper bits lay tangled
right in the glass of the mo
ssed through old, lined they
rs turned slowly, endlessly
counting down to. The sou
s no one had seen. but ev

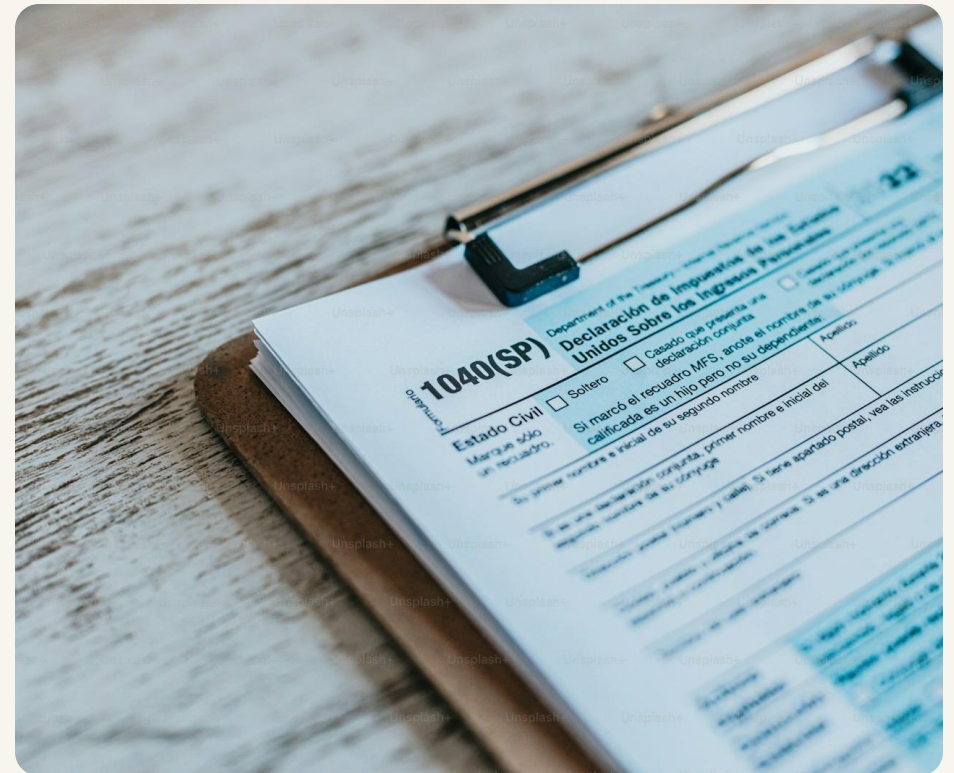
Audit tooling and process

Automated scanners are a fast first pass, never the whole review.

Automated tools such as axe DevTools, Lighthouse and WAVE reliably catch missing attributes and contrast failures. They cannot judge whether alt text is meaningful, whether a tab order makes sense, or whether captions are accurate.

Automated pass

Manual pass



What automated tools miss vs. catch

Knowing the boundary tells you where to spend manual review time.

Finding	Detected by	Note
Missing alt attribute	Automated	Flags the absence, not whether text present is meaningful
Contrast ratio below threshold	Automated	Measures precisely against the numeric ratio
Alt text quality and relevance	Manual	Requires human judgement of purpose and context
Logical tab order	Manual	Requires an actual keyboard pass through the page
Caption accuracy	Manual	Requires watching with sound off, captions on

Universal design — the physical and digital parallel

Accessible features built for a specific need routinely help everyone.

An accessible parking space or a kerb cut was built for wheelchair users, but a parent with a stroller and a delivery worker with a trolley use it too. Digital accessibility features work the same way.

Captions

See the video transcript and audio description for more details.

High contrast

See the video transcript and audio description for more details.



Severity and prioritisation

Not every finding blocks a task equally — triage before you fix.

Severity	Definition	Example
Critical	Blocks a core task entirely for some users	Keyboard trap in the checkout form
Serious	Makes a task very difficult but not impossible	Contrast failure on primary body text
Moderate	Adds friction without blocking the task	Inconsistent heading levels
Minor	Cosmetic or edge-case impact	Slightly imprecise alt text on a decorative image

Writing up a finding

A finding is only useful to a developer if it is specific enough to act on.

1

Location: the exact page, component or element where the problem occurs.

2

Criterion: the specific WCAG success criterion it fails, by number.

3

Impact: which users are blocked, and how severely (see the previous slide).

4

Fix and retest: a concrete proposed change, and how you will confirm it worked.

A finding without a WCAG reference is an opinion; a finding with one is a testable claim.

Week 8 studio audit

What you produce and submit for this session.

Brief	Choose a page from your own project or a public site. Run the five-part audit: headings, contrast, focus visibility, text alternatives and motion settings.
Constraints	Every finding must name its WCAG 2.2 success criterion and a severity rating. Test at least one check with a real keyboard-only or screen-reader pass, not tooling alone.
Evidence to submit	A five-row findings table (check, WCAG reference, severity, evidence, proposed fix) and 100 words on the single highest-severity finding.

Review rubric

How this audit is assessed, and how it feeds into Assignment 3.

Coverage

All five checks attempted, not just the easiest ones.

Accuracy

Each finding cites the correct WCAG 2.2 success criterion.

Evidence

Findings include what was tested and how, not just an assertion.

Actionability

Each finding pairs with one concrete, testable proposed fix.

Common findings from real audits

The same handful of problems recur across almost every unreviewed site.

Structure

Skipped heading levels; multiple h1s;
landmark regions missing or
duplicated.

Interaction

Removed focus outlines; keyboard
traps in modals and menus;
unlabelled icon buttons.

Media and colour

Body text under 4.5:1 contrast;
decorative alt text on informative
images; uncaptioned video.

Recognising these patterns quickly is what turns a slow audit into a fast one.

Recommended practice and preparation

Before next session.

Standards reference

W3C, Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2: <https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG22/>

Tooling reference

WebAIM, Contrast Checker: <https://webaim.org/resources/contrastchecker/> — W3C WAI, How to Meet WCAG (Quick Reference): <https://www.w3.org/WAI/WCAG22/quickref/>

Bring to Week 9

Your completed five-part audit findings table, ready to inform this week's content-system and navigation planning.